



Timbre

Clean audio for transcription, straight from your Mac



Stop pointing your microphone at your own speakers. Timbre records what is playing inside your computer — YouTube lives, Zoom, Google Meet, anything — and hands you a clean MP3 ready for Otter or any transcription tool.

Everything runs on your Mac. Nothing is uploaded anywhere.

You do not need to know how to code to use this.

? Why this exists

We often need a recording of something playing on screen — a YouTube livestream, a Zoom or Google Meet call, a hearing being streamed — so it can go to Otter or another transcription tool.

Until now the only way was to **play it out loud and let the Mac's microphone pick it up**. That approach carries real problems:

Recording through the microphone

- Speakers have to stay **on and loud**, disturbing colleagues around you
- The room gets recorded too — chatter, typing, air conditioning
- A phone call mirrored to your Mac cuts straight into the recording
- Quality drops: what you get is a recording of a recording

Recording with Timbre

- Sound is taken **from the sound card itself**, before it reaches any speaker
- Nothing from the room gets in — only the audio you are capturing
- Volume is irrelevant: keep it low, use headphones, or mute it entirely
- Same quality as the original source, ready to upload for transcription

It works with **any source and any browser** — Chrome, Safari, Firefox, a desktop app, a media player. If your Mac can play it, Timbre can record it.

Everything happens on your computer. No internet connection, no cloud service, no account, no upload. The recording is a file on your Desktop and nobody else ever sees it — which matters when the material is sensitive or embargoed.

? How you will use it

Click the icon before the talk starts, listen to it normally while it records, click again when it ends. An MP3 appears on your Desktop. Drag it into Otter.

Requires macOS 14.4 or later. Setup takes about five minutes and only needs to be done once.

1 Open Terminal

Press **⌘ + Space**, type **Terminal** and press **Return**.



A window with plain text will open. You only need it for the setup — after this you will never open it again.

2 Copy and paste these two lines

Copy the first line, paste it into Terminal, press **Return** and wait for it to finish. Then do the same with the second one.

```
git clone https://github.com/ipatrickbr/timbre.git ~/timbre
```

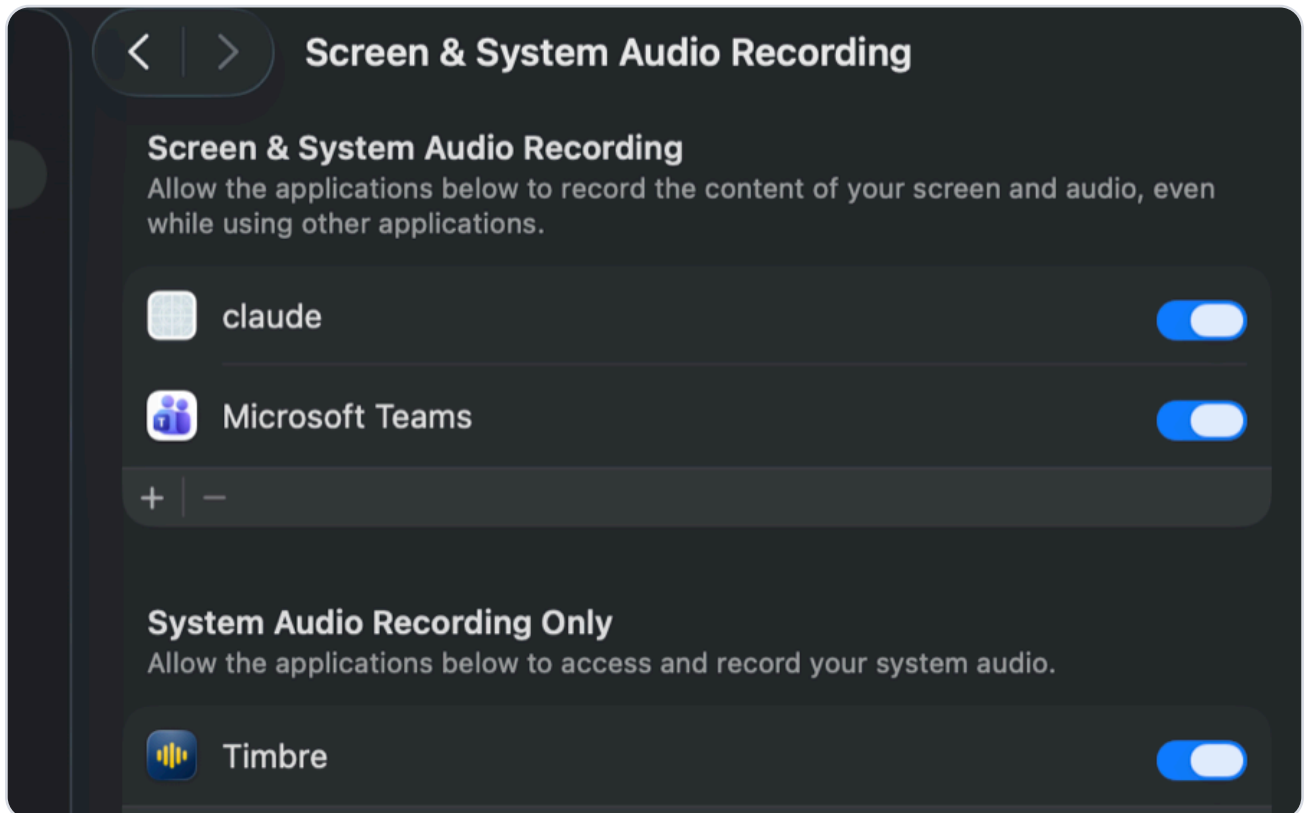
```
cd ~/timbre && ./vendor/build-lame.sh && ./build.sh
```

The second line takes a minute or two. Lots of text will scroll past — that is normal. It is done when you see **installed:** followed by a path.

If macOS asks you to install the **command line developer tools**, click **Install** and wait for it to finish, then run the line again.

3 Give Timbre permission

Open **Timbre** from Launchpad. The first time, macOS will ask for permission to record system audio. Go to **System Settings** › **Privacy & Security** › **Screen & System Audio Recording** and switch **Timbre** on.



Timbre appears under **System Audio Recording Only** — it can hear your Mac's audio, and nothing else. It cannot see your screen.

4 Find the icon

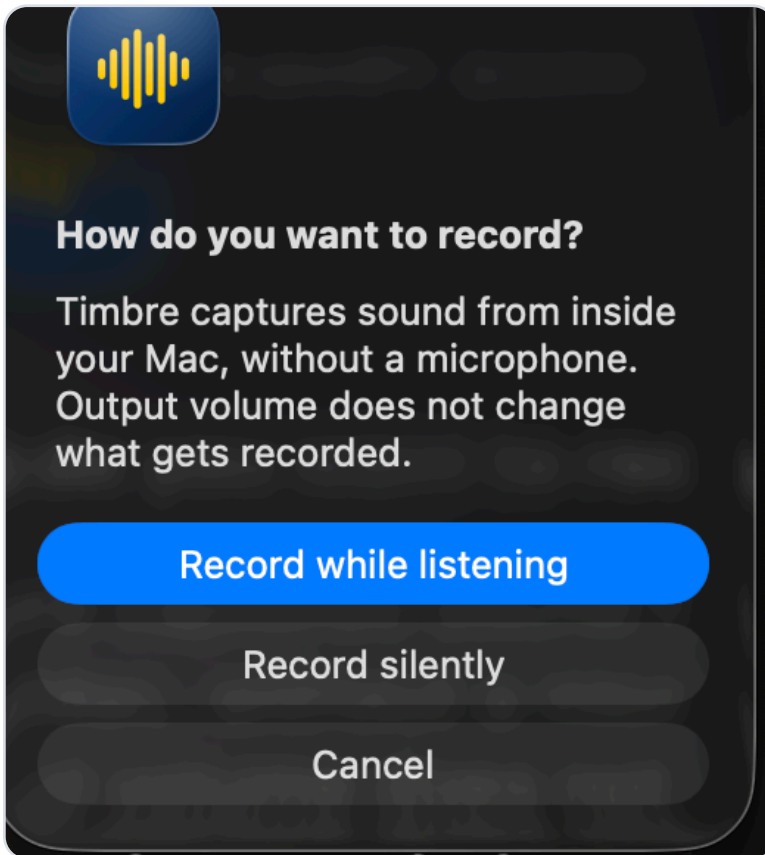
Timbre lives in the menu bar at the top of your screen, as a small waveform.



Click it to start recording.

5 Choose how to record

Clicking the icon asks you one question:

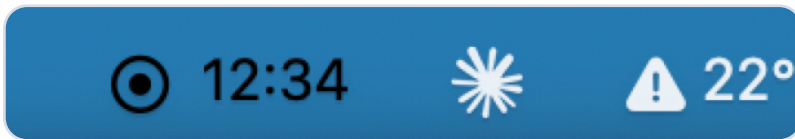


Record while listening is what you want almost always — you hear the talk normally and it records at the same time.

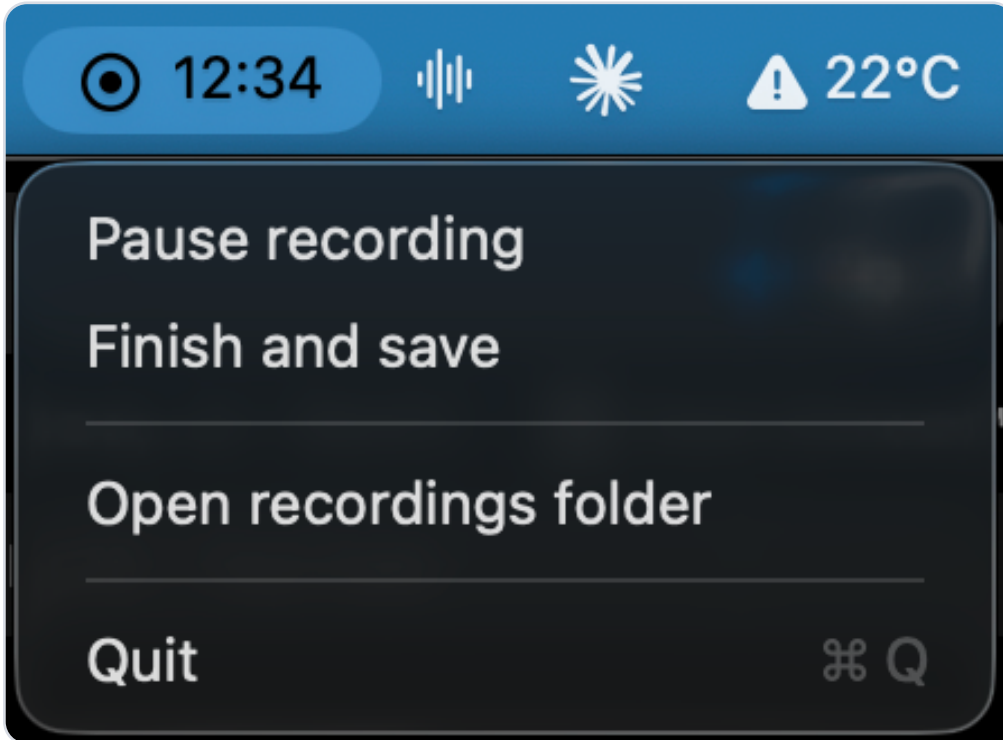
Record silently mutes your speakers while recording. Useful if you need the audio but not the noise.

6 While it records

The icon turns into a recording dot with a running clock.



Click it again at any time to **pause** or to **finish**:

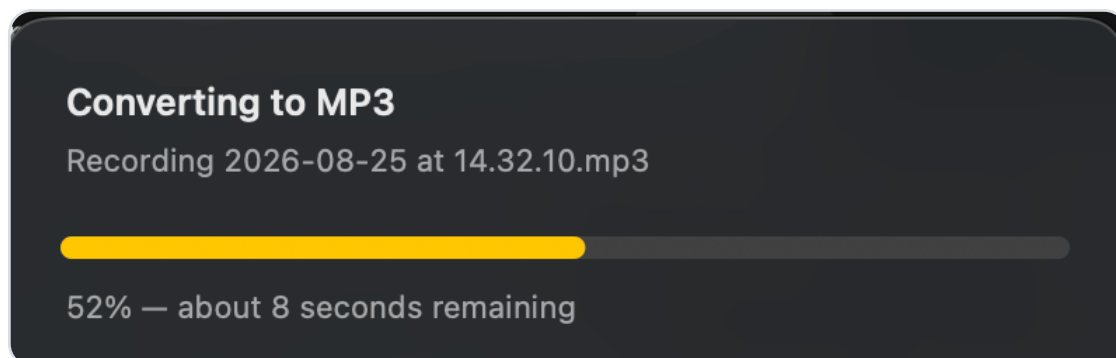


Pausing leaves that stretch out of the file and picks up again in the same recording — handy when a hearing breaks for recess.

If the icon says **no sound** instead of a clock, nothing is playing on your Mac yet. Press play on the stream and the clock starts.

7 Wait a moment for the file

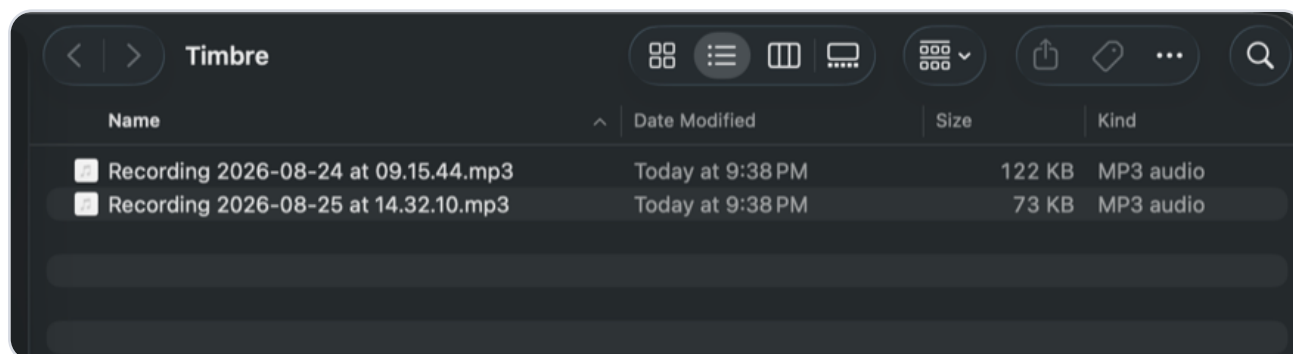
When you finish, Timbre turns the recording into an MP3 and shows you how long it will take.



A two-hour hearing takes under a minute. Do not close anything — the folder opens by itself when it is ready.

8 Where your recordings are

Everything goes into a folder called **Timbre**, on your Desktop. It opens automatically at the end of every recording, with the new file already selected.



Files are named by date and time. Double-click to play, or drag into your transcription tool.

If something goes wrong

The recording came out silent. Permission is almost always the cause. Check step 3 — macOS gives silence rather than an error when the permission is missing.

No file appeared. Nothing was playing during the recording. Timbre does not create a file when there is no sound at all.

The icon vanished after restarting. Open Timbre from Launchpad again. To have it always there, add it in **System Settings › General › Login Items**.

The file is shorter than the time I recorded. That is expected. Recording starts at the first sound, so silence before the talk begins is not included. Nothing is lost.

Timbre is free and open source · github.com/ipatrickbr/timbre
Questions? Ask Igor.